

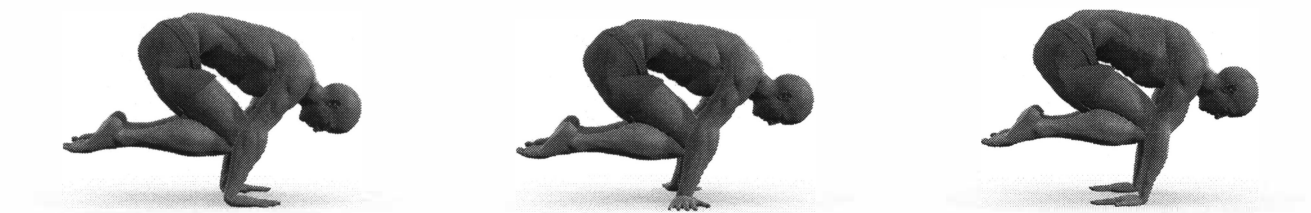
PUSHING VARIATIONS

Planche – Parallel Bars and Floor – Page 3, Column 1

The *planche* requires an unfathomable amount of straight-arm pushing strength. While it can sometimes seem that everyone engaging in bodyweight training is striving for this skill; however, those who can perform it well are few and far between.

Many Internet videos now feature this skill and suggest methods for training toward it. However, in most every case, you will find that the subjects in these videos have an extremely arched spine and slightly bent arms. These form errors do more than make the skill less aesthetically appealing; they also make the skill much easier to perform, thus sacrificing overall strength gains. You may hear of people obtaining a “*planche*” in under a year, but it is likely not a pure variation of this skill.

If an authentic *planche* is one of your primary goals, avoid form errors, as you would only be cheating yourself out of proper strength development. While it will take longer to achieve an authentic *planche*, your body positioning and overall level of strength will be significantly better, which will transfer to other bodyweight strength skills as well.



There are a few different hand positions you can use for the *planche*, each with its own pros and cons. *Hands forward* makes the skill easier because you have more leverage in your fingers but the movement is harder on your wrists than the following positions. *Hands to the side* easily transfers from the floor to parallel bars or from parallel bars to rings, but it makes the skill more difficult than the previous position. *Hands backward* makes the skill the most difficult but directly works your biceps to build large muscles and connective tissue strength.

Unless you have other reasons for desiring the first or third option, *hands to the side* is recommended—being the most applicable and causing the least amount of wrist irritation—but any of these positions will

work. Those who want to work the planche as quickly as possible will probably find the *hands forward* position is best for them, while those who will perform a lot of specific work on the rings would benefit from using the *hands backward position*. (If you choose the *hands forward* position, make sure to include extra wrist work in your routine to prevent overuse injuries.)

You will likely get frustrated while working toward the planche, simply because it takes so long to get there. Remember, you do not know the strength and condition of those who claim they were able to achieve the position in a short amount of time; they may have had five to ten years of other strength training under their belt, thus speeding up their rate of progress. The key to training for the planche is *consistency*—even in your supplemental work. If you keep changing up your routine, do not expect to excel at this skill.

For the planche position, your shoulders should be tight and active, and your scapulas should be protracted and depressed as far as possible. This is done by pressing deep into the ground with your hands, arms, and shoulders as one unit, thus resisting all of the downward force on your body. This active position is essential to keep your shoulders safe from impingement, to allow better leverage, and to correctly position your body. This same position is used in many other movements and holds like L-sits, dips, and rings support work.

FROG STAND – LEVEL 3



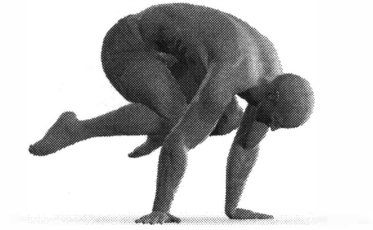
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Grip the ground or parallettes firmly and lean forward with bent arms until most of the weight is on your hands. Slowly place one knee at a time on the shelf created by your slightly bent elbows. Once you can balance in this position, lean forward until your shoulders and hips are level.

The *frog stand* is less of a strength skill and more of a balance skill. That is not to say it does not require any strength, but most of your focus will be on getting a feel for the position. One of the alternative ways to move into this position is to begin in a tripod position with your hands and head on the ground, like in a headstand. You then bring down your knees to your elbows and slowly shift your weight backward onto your hands for balance.

As with all the planche skills from here on out, you should prepare your body for the “I’m going to face plant!” sensation. This is normal and a big part of moving up from one progression to the next. You can fight this sensation with your shoulders. Do not bend your elbows (except in the frog stand). This is a bad habit that can be hard to break. The core of your pressing ability should be straight-arm strength through your shoulders.

STRAIGHT-ARM FROG STAND – LEVEL 4



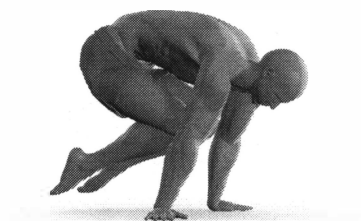
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Lean forward with your arms straight (instead of bent), while maintaining active shoulders and a tight grip. As you lean forward, place your knees directly above your elbows. Unlike the previous progression, there is no longer a shelf to assist you. Therefore, you will have to rely on your shoulder and abdominal strength.

When you begin the *straight-arm frog stand*, you may find that you have to slightly bend your arms (as in the illustration above). This is acceptable initially, as this skill is primarily about balance. However, once you straighten your arms the position becomes more about shoulder strength. You will have to lean forward a bit more than you did in the previous progression, which increases the difficulty level. If you get a “face plant” sensation, you will want to fight it now to prepare for future skills.

This skill is somewhat of an intermediary position between the frog stand (which is performed with bent arms) and the tuck planche. Performing this skill with straight arms is fundamental in order to build the correct amount of strength for the planche. Do not move onto the next progression until you can perform this skill without bending your elbows even a little bit.

TUCK PLANCHE – LEVEL 5



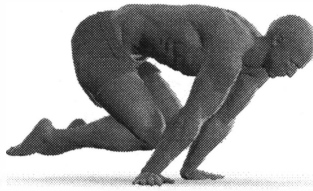
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Begin in the bottom of a squat. Place your hands on the ground or parallettes and grip firmly. Keep your arms locked straight and your shoulders tight and active. Lean forward to shift your weight from your feet to your arms. From there, continue leaning forward and raising your hips until they reach shoulder height and you are in a tuck planche position. You should keep your knees to your chest as tightly as possible and your feet tucked toward your butt.

The *tuck planche* is the first skill in this series of progressions that relies solely on shoulder strength to support the body. Fear of face-planting is often an issue for beginners. It is important to reduce your fear so you can concentrate on properly performing the strength technique. Lay a pillow or other soft cushion on the floor in front of your hands, just in case you fall.

Another issue can arise when this skill is performed on the ground. You may find that you cannot get into a good tuck position with your knees and feet tight. This is an issue of core compression strength, and it can be improved in conjunction with your L-sit training. Concurrently train the tuck planche with your core compression work by using an implement like parallettes or two sturdy twin chairs. Aim to tuck hard and get your knees and feet as close as possible to your chest and butt, respectively. Finally, do not ever forget to keep your shoulders active and strong.

ADVANCED TUCK PLANCHE – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Begin in the bottom of a squat. Place your hands on the ground or parallettes and grip firmly. Keep your arms locked straight and your shoulders tight and active. Lean forward to shift your weight from your feet to your arms. From there, continue leaning forward and raising your hips until they reach shoulder height and you are in a tuck planche position. You should keep your knees to your chest as tightly as possible and your feet tucked toward your butt. Slowly straighten out your back and extend your legs to the ninety-degree hip angle.

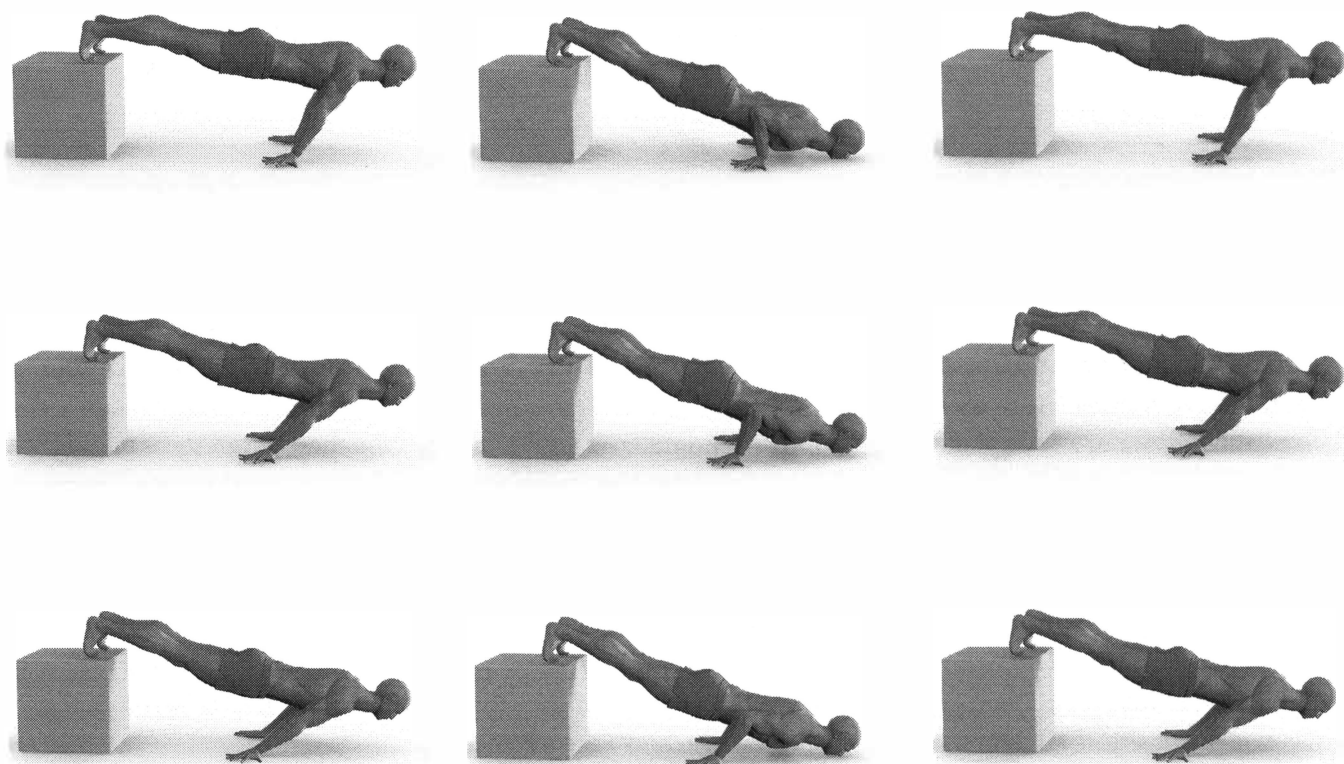
The *advanced tuck planche* takes the tuck planche and flattens out the back while continuing to keep the hips and shoulders in line and parallel with the ground. At this point, you should have fairly good command over your tuck position. Dragging your feet will not be an issue when training on the floor. Lock your arms and shoulders and lean forward, placing your weight on your hands while gripping the ground hard. From the tuck planche position, straighten your back until you achieve the advanced position.

At first, you may have a difficult time figuring out how to straighten your back. A lack of back control can typically be corrected by training straight-arm press handstand progressions. Both the planche and straight-arm press handstands are straight-arm pressing skills that work synergistically to increase shoulder strength. They also facilitate core strength and awareness.

To increase the difficulty of the skill, straighten your back. This will cause you to lean forward more and this increases the torque at your shoulders. If your feet start to sag toward the floor as you straighten out, you are likely facing one of two problems: Either you simply need to lean forward more, or your level of strength is inadequate and you should return to the previous progression until you are ready for this advanced skill.

As fatigue management allows, adding supplemental work will be extremely useful to help develop the strength needed to obtain a planche. Any other shoulder-based pressing movements can also act as drivers for better shoulder pressing strength, but specificity would be very helpful here. As such, pseudo planche push-ups and planche leans are a great choice; however, they are a bit hard to measure, which is why they are not listed on the progression charts.

PSEUDO PLANCHE PUSHUPS



Progressive pseudo planche pushups move your hands further back.

Pseudo planche pushups (which can be abbreviated *PPPUs*) are, in essence, a best attempt to simulate holding the planche position and completing a pushup in that position, but with some assistance. When progress is stalling, these can help significantly.

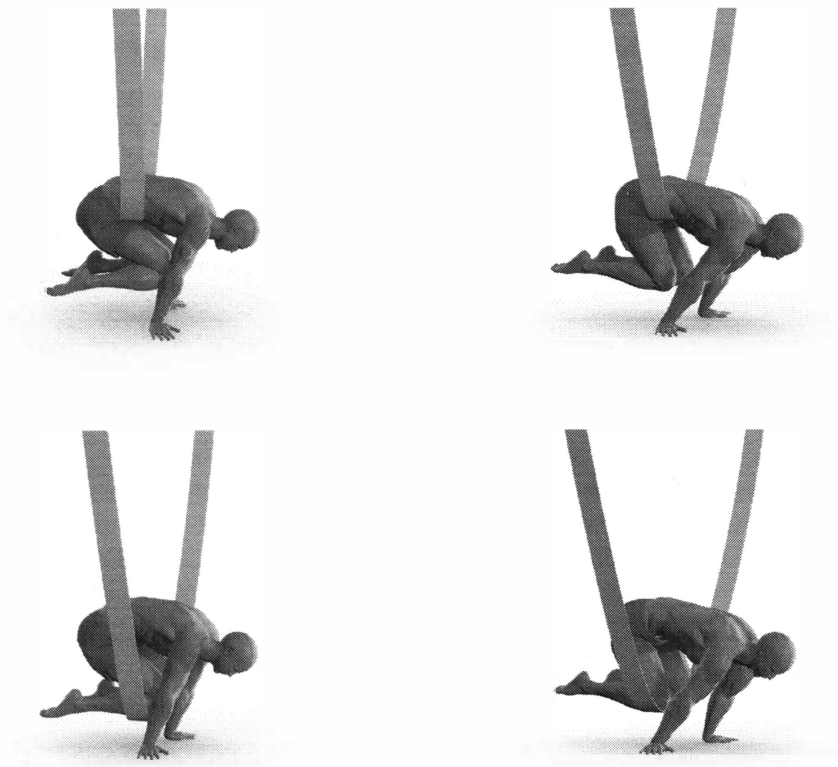
Begin in a standard pushup position, but place your feet on an implement instead of on the ground. The implement could be a box, mat, chair—anything that is high enough to align your feet with your shoulders horizontally. With a straight or slightly hollow body, lean forward as far as possible into the planche position and lower yourself so that your shoulders are at least as low as your elbows. Then, push back up to a feet-supported planche position.

A *planche lean* is exactly what it says it is. Prop your feet up to shoulder height and lean forward as far as possible without tipping over. Hold this position for a set amount of time.

From this progression onward, it is common to want to bend your arms slightly or have your hips slightly higher than your shoulders. These errors should be carefully avoided. The proper position will be difficult to hold, due to strength requirements as well as body awareness, but you want to ensure that you are holding it correctly. You should experience a “face plant” sensation, and your hips will likely feel lower than they actually are. Use a spotter or camera to check your form.

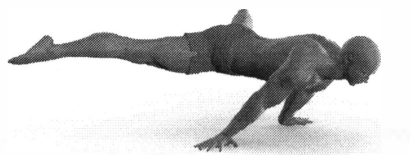
As a supplementary exercise for the planche, PPPUs are excellent. The way to make these measurable is to always place the block or chair or other elevated surface in the same place. You can mark it on the floor. Next, mark the distance for the hands progressively as you move them back. You can either mark it from the place where you regularly do pushups or the total distance from your feet. Whatever way you mark them, PPPUs are a great way to begin to gain the increased strength necessary for the planche.

BAND-ASSISTED PLANCHE



The *band-assisted planche* is one of the variations that has become recently popular. This variation allows you to hit the next isometric position in the planche with decreased strength requirements. The body is able to quickly get used to the position and the application of correct strength at particular angles, which may decrease the amount of time it takes to achieve the strength the planche requires. Pseudo planche pushups are preferred over this method, but try both and see which works best for you.

STRADDLE PLANCHE – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Begin in the bottom of a squat. Place your hands on the ground or parallettes and grip firmly. Keep your arms locked straight and your shoulders tight and active. Lean forward to shift your weight from your feet to your arms. From there, continue leaning forward and raising your hips until they reach shoulder height and you are in a straight-body position with your legs apart. You should maintain a straight line from your shoulders through your hips/knees/ankles to your toes, but you should also have your legs spread as far apart as possible.

There are a few ways to achieve the *straddle planche* position, whether on the ground or parallettes. The most common method involves leaning into the skill with your hips slightly bent, and then lifting your legs off the ground once you are balanced on your hands. Another method is to jump into the position and attempt to balance it from there. While this is more difficult, some will prefer this method. Pick whichever feels more natural to you and maintain proper body positioning.

By now, your straddle should be proficient because you have practiced it in press handstands, abdominal compression work, and the back and front lever progressions. If your straddle is not proficient, make time for more straddle work before attempting this skill.

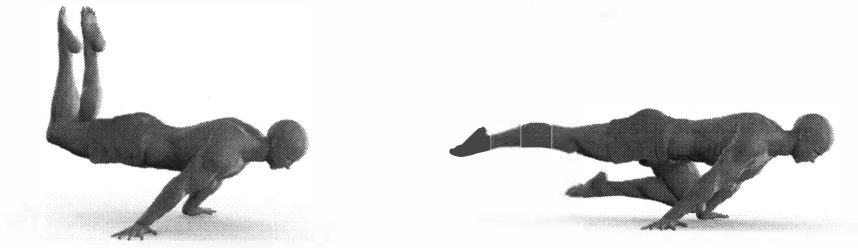
In most cases, supplemental work is required to attain a straddle planche. Commonly, three exercises are used in tandem. The first is the planche isometric, and the other two are supplemental dynamic pressing movements (like planche progression pushups and/or pseudo planche pushups with a dipping or handstand press variation).

To bridge the gap from the advanced tuck to the straddle position you can use the assisted straddle planche or any advanced tuck variation with a higher level of difficulty, such as adding ankle weights or a weighted vest while performing the advanced tuck position. Alternatively, you can use Therabands or other elastic bands to make the straddle planche easier.

Avoid the bent-arms and hips-too-high faults! Use a camera, mirror, or spotter to evaluate and correct your form.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

HALF LAYOUT / ONE-LEG-OUT PLANCHE – LEVEL 9



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique for *Half-Layout*: Begin in the bottom of a squat. Place your hands on the ground or parallelles and grip firmly. Keep your arms locked straight and your shoulders tight and active. Lean forward to shift your weight from your feet to your arms. From there, continue leaning forward and raising your hips until they reach shoulder height and you are in a half-layout position: Your knees and legs are together and all of your joints are aligned—from your shoulders through your hips and knees through your legs—except your knees are bent at a ninety-degree angle.

Technique for *One-Leg-Out Planche*: Begin in the bottom of a squat position, with your hands firmly gripping the ground or parallelles. Lock your arms straight and keep your shoulders tight and active. Lean forward to shift all of your weight off your feet onto your arms. From there, continue leaning forward and raise your hips until they reach shoulder height and you are in a one-leg-out position, which is the same as the straight-body position except one leg is bent at both the hips and the knee, leaving it in a position that is similar to an advanced tuck.

The half layout position is preferred, as the form more easily transfers to the full layout position. However, if there is another position that feels more natural for you, use it. Regardless of which position you choose, your form must be flawless. If you notice any faults, correct them immediately.

This progression is an optional intermediate step between the straddle planche and the full planche. Most people will try to skip this stage and go straight to the full planche. If you can achieve the position, go for it. Or, you can use this progression to bridge the gap.

FULL PLANCHE – LEVEL 11



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Begin in the bottom of a squat. Place your hands on the ground or parallel bars and grip firmly. Keep your arms locked straight and your shoulders tight and active. Lean forward to shift your weight from your feet to your arms. From there, continue leaning forward and raising your hips until they reach shoulder height and you are in a full planche position with your body aligned straight from your shoulders through your torso/hips/knees/ankles to your toes. Your toes should be pointed and your body should be parallel with the ground.

The key with the *full planche* is—like every other skill in this progression—overcoming the face-plant sensation. You should be leaning far enough over that you feel very low to the ground and close to falling on your face. Make sure that you are generating full-body tension by squeezing all of the muscles in your core, glutes, and legs. One of the things that can help generate tension for this skill is to squeeze your hands together while pressing them forward. The extra tension generated from your pectorals and serratus anterior helps increase all of the muscle activity around your shoulder girdle. This can help you attain the last bit of strength needed to execute this skill.

Like the straddle planche, the full planche typically requires some specific supplementary work. By this point you should know what works best for you. What usually holds people back is a lack of musculature or potential imbalances. If you are weak with pulling movements and back strength, work on strengthening your scapular retractors, posterior deltoids, and rotator cuff muscles. If there is no imbalance, you may benefit from performing more high-repetition hypertrophy work in order to gain more muscle mass. Remember, *strength = neural adaptations * cross sectional area of muscle*. The small amount of weight added at your shoulder for more muscle mass is also beneficial for gaining strength and will not hinder you as much as you may think.

Once you have achieved clean, perfect straight-body positioning, be sure to take a photo—you are holding a planche! Congratulations! This is no easy feat.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

STRAIGHT-ARM STRADDLE PLANCHE TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 12



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back. As your body rises, your scapulas will transition from protracted to neutral and from depressed to elevated. In the ending handstand position, your scapulas will be fully elevated.

Technique: Begin in a straddle planche position. To initiate the movement, lean forward slightly and increase pressure through your hands to begin lifting your hips. As you move toward the handstand and the torque on your shoulders lessens, the skill will become slightly easier.

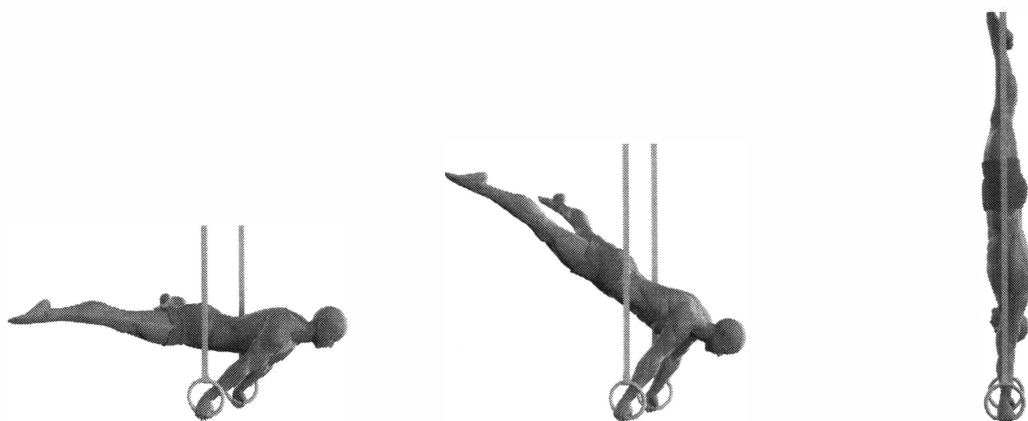
The *straight-arm straddle planche to handstand* skill (which can be abbreviated *SA Str PL to HS*) can be completed on the FX (ground) or PB (parallel bars). The illustration above depicts it on the FX. This skill is executed by leaning forward into the straddle planche position and then pressing out to a handstand. This technique requires brute strength, so if you are proficient with planches and handstands you can begin to work toward this skill. It is usually easiest to begin by doing it in reverse. Then, once you are stronger and more familiar with the skill, you can perform the full movement.

The main thing to keep in mind is to maintain active shoulders and a straight body. Once you begin leaning forward, it is much like a regular press handstand: You will need to force your hands overhead strongly. You will naturally want to arch your back but this must be avoided.

Avoid bending your arms and arching your back. (It is acceptable to arch your back a little initially, but you will want to eliminate this fault as you get stronger.)

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM STRADDLE PLANCHE TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 14



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back. As your body rises, your scapulas will transition from protracted to neutral and from depressed to elevated. In the ending handstand position, your scapulas will be fully elevated.

Technique: Same as the previous progression, but on the rings. Begin in a straddle planche position. To initiate the movement, lean forward slightly and increase pressure through your hands to begin lifting your hips. As you move toward the handstand position, the skill will become slightly easier as the torque on your shoulders lessens.

Brute strength is necessary to achieve the *rings straight-arm straddle planche to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *Rings SA Str PL to HS*). If you are proficient with planches and handstands you can begin to work toward this skill. It is usually easiest to begin solely in reverse. Then, once you are stronger and more familiar with the skill, you can perform the full movement.

The main thing to keep in mind with this skill is maintaining active shoulders and a straight body. Once you begin leaning forward, it is like a regular press handstand in that you will need to force your hands overhead strongly. You will naturally want to arch your back but this must be avoided.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points, though it is much more difficult than a typical Level 12 skill. Based on previous skills and progressions it should probably be rated Level 13 or 14, around the lower end of Level C on the Code of Points.

STRAIGHT-ARM, STRAIGHT-BODY FROM PLANCHE TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 15



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back. As your body rises, your scapulas will transition from protracted to neutral and from depressed to elevated. In the ending handstand position, your scapulas will be fully elevated.

Technique: Begin in a full planche position. To initiate the movement, lean forward slightly and increase pressure through your hands to begin lifting your hips. As you move toward the handstand position, the skill will become slightly easier as the torque on your shoulders lessens.

The technique and approach here is the same as the *straddle planche to handstand*. Lean forward and allow yourself to rotate up to a handstand position, while maintaining enough force at your shoulder to prevent yourself from falling forward. Work this skill eccentrically, then concentrically.

This skill is more difficult than the previous two progressions because it begins statically, in the planche position. This means you will have no momentum to help you achieve the handstand position. If you can achieve this skill, you have achieved a rare and remarkable level of strength.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM, STRAIGHT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 16

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be either depressed and neutral or slightly protracted to start. As you lean forward and your body rises, your scapulas will transition from depressed to elevated and protracted to neutral. In the ending handstand position, your scapulas will be fully elevated.

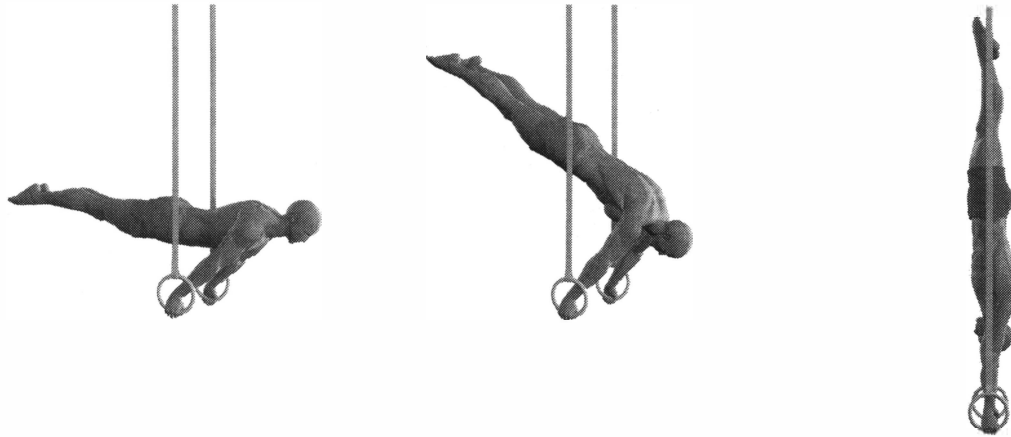
Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in the support position. To initiate the movement, lean forward slightly and increase pressure through your hands to begin lifting your hips. As you move up through a full planche toward the handstand position, the skill will become slightly easier as the torque on your shoulders lessens. Finish in a rings handstand position.

The *rings straight-arm, straight-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *Rings SA SB to HS*) is essentially a *straight-arm hollowback press*. If you are proficient with the hollowback press and planche, you can begin to work toward this skill. This is a very difficult skill, so you may need to use some momentum when you are first learning it. As you increase in strength, decrease the amount of momentum used.

This skill can be practiced in reverse, beginning in a handstand. Additionally, you can swing on the rings a bit before initiating the movement if you cannot quite achieve it with strict form. Your body will naturally want to arch, but you must remember to keep your body straight for the entire duration of the movement.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM, STRAIGHT-BODY FROM PLANCHE TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 16



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back. As your body rises, your scapulas will transition from protracted to neutral and from depressed to elevated. In the ending handstand position, your scapulas will be fully elevated.

Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in planche position. To initiate the movement, lean forward slightly and increase pressure through your hands to begin lifting your hips. As you move toward the handstand position, the skill will become slightly easier as the torque on your shoulders lessens. Finish in the rings handstand position.

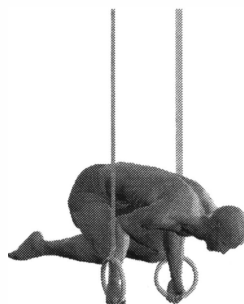
The technique is the same as two progressions before, but you will complete it on the rings. This skill should be worked eccentrically, then concentrically.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

Rings Planche – Page 3, Column 2

The rings planche positions are the same as the floor and parallettes variations. The only real difference is orienting your hands to maintain control and stability over the rings. Of course, this is the hard part. This is why all of the planche skills in the Gymnastics Code of Points are one letter grade more difficult on the rings as opposed to the floor and parallel bars. Strength gains from performing these holds on rings are phenomenal and carry over extensively to their floor and parallettes' counterparts.

RINGS FROG STAND – LEVEL 4



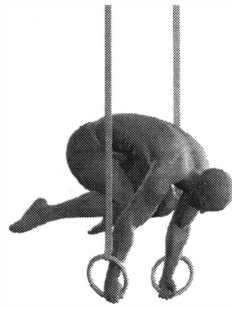
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Plant your hands on the rings and grip tightly. Lean forward with bent arms and slowly place one knee at a time on the shelf created by your slightly bent elbows. Once you can balance in that position, lean forward until your shoulders are level with your hips.

Orient the rings to the parallel position. You do not want them turned out yet because you still need to use your elbow area as a resting point for your legs. From here, the approach will be the same as a frog stand performed on the floor or parallettes.

The rings will feel very shaky when you begin this skill. By this point, you should be proficient in RTO support work and, potentially, rings pushups as well. These two movements will help substantially as you learn how to stabilize the rings while they are in front of you.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM FROG STAND – LEVEL 5

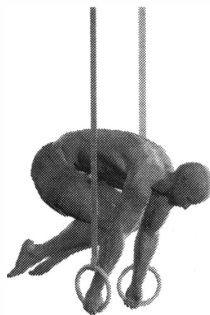


Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: Plant your hands on the rings and grip tightly. Lean forward with straight arms and place your knees right above your elbows as you did in the previous progression. However, there will no longer be a shelf to assist you, which means this skill will require more shoulder strength.

When you begin the *rings straight-arm frog stand*, you may have to slightly bend your arms (as in the illustration above). This is acceptable initially, as this skill is primarily about balance. However, once you straighten your arms the position becomes more about shoulder strength. It is important to use straight arms for this movement in order to build the strength required for future progressions. Do not move onto the next progression until you can perform this skill without bending your elbows.

For the straight-arm frog stand, orient the rings to the parallel position. You do not want them turned out just yet because you still need to use your elbow area as a resting point for your legs. From here, the approach will be the same as a frog stand performed on the floor or parallel bars.

RINGS TUCK PLANCHE – LEVEL 6

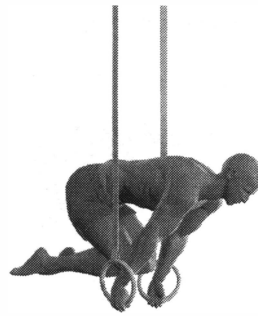
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in a support position and lean forward, taking all your weight off your feet until they are airborne. From there, continue to lean forward and raise your hips until they reach shoulder height. Your knees should be held to your chest as tight as possible, and your feet should be tucked to your butt.

This is where the technique differs: Instead of orienting the rings in the parallel position like you would on the parallettes, turn them out to forty-five degrees past the parallel position. This will give you more control. Coaches may prefer anywhere from forty-five to ninety degrees past the parallel position, but this is not required unless you want to specialize in gymnastics.

The main difficulty will be keeping your hips at shoulder height and your arms tightly locked in a straight position. This will be the case for all of the following rings planche progressions.

RINGS ADVANCED TUCK PLANCHE – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in a support position and lean forward, taking all your weight off your feet until they are airborne. From there, continue to lean forward and raise your hips until they reach shoulder height. Next, flatten out your back while continuing to keep your hips and shoulders in line and parallel with the ground and at a ninety-degree angle (where your hips meet your torso).

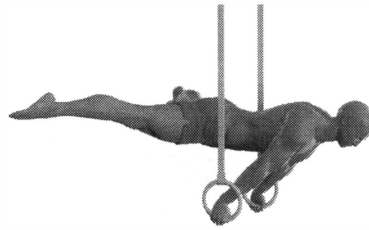
The rings should be turned out to at least forty-five degrees. The rest of the technique for this skill is the same as the variation performed on the floor or parallettes.

You will lean forward while locking your arms and shoulders. This will place your weight on your hands as you grip the rings tightly. Start from the tuck planche position and straighten your back until you achieve the advanced tuck position.

You may have a difficult time figuring out how to straighten your back. This lack of back control can be remedied by training the straight-arm press handstand progression. Both the planche and straight-arm press handstands are straight-arm pressing skills that work synergistically to increase shoulder strength. They also facilitate core awareness and strength; both of which help fix issues like this one.

Straightening out will cause you to lean forward more and thus increase the torque at your shoulders, which increases the difficulty of the skill. If your feet begin to sag toward the floor as you straighten out, it is likely caused by one of two problems: either you simply need to lean forward more, or your level of strength is not adequate and you should return to the previous progression.

RINGS STRADDLE PLANCHE – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in a support position and lean forward, taking all your weight off your feet until they are airborne. From there, continue to lean forward and raise your hips until they reach shoulder height. Make sure the line from your hips through your hips/knees to your toes is straight and parallel with the ground. Keep your legs spread as far apart as possible.

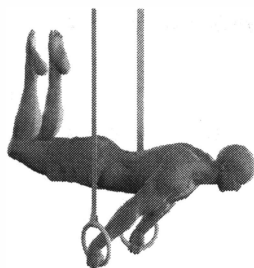
Again, the rings need to be turned out to forty-five degrees or more. The rest of the technique for this skill is the same as the variation performed on the floor or parallettes. By now, you should be proficient with the straddle movement because of the practice you have gotten with press handstands, abdominal compression work, and back and front lever progressions. If your straddle still needs work, hone it before training this skill.

Once you are on the rings, there are two ways to move into position. You can either lean forward into the skill from the support position or begin from a tuck planche and extend your legs. You can also execute this skill from the floor or a mat near rings height by leaning into the position, similar to the floor and parallettes progressions. As long as proper body positioning is maintained, any of these will work.

Remember to avoid the bent-arms and hips-too-high faults! Use a camera, mirror, or spotter to evaluate and correct your form.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS HALF LAYOUT / ONE-LEG-OUT PLANCHE – LEVEL 12

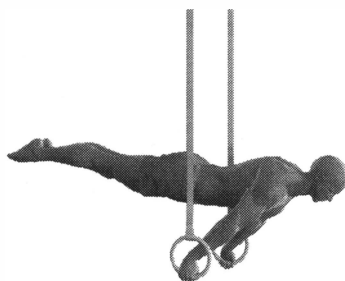


Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in a support position and lean forward, taking all your weight off your feet until they are airborne. From there, continue to lean forward and raise your hips until they reach shoulder height and move into a half layout position. This means your knees and legs are together and all of your joints are aligned—from your shoulders through your hips and knees through your legs—except your knees are bent at a ninety-degree angle. If you prefer to use the one-leg-out position over the half layout, it involves the same straight-body position except one leg is bent at both the hips and knee, similar to an advanced tuck position.

When you get to this point, you may want to turn the rings out a bit more in order to stress your biceps and create more tension in your upper body, resulting in increased stability. The rest of the technique for this skill is the same as the variation performed on the floor or parallel bars. Use the position that works best for you, although the half layout position's form transfers more quickly to the full layout position. Maintain proper form and correct any faults immediately.

RINGS FULL PLANCHE – LEVEL 14



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and depressed without rounding your upper back.

Technique: This skill is completed on the rings. Begin in a support position and lean forward, taking all your weight off your feet until they are airborne. From there, continue to lean forward and raise your hips until they reach shoulder height. Next, align your shoulders with your hips/knees/ankles to reach the full planche position.

On the FIG Gymnastics A-G scale, the *rings full planche* is a C-level skill. Though Level G is the highest level on the scale, by the time you reach Level C you have achieved an impressive amount of strength. To put it in perspective, a planche on parallel bars and an iron cross are both only B-level skills. If you have reached this level, you probably no longer need advice from this book.

Planche Pushups – Parallel Bars and Floor – Page 3, Column 3

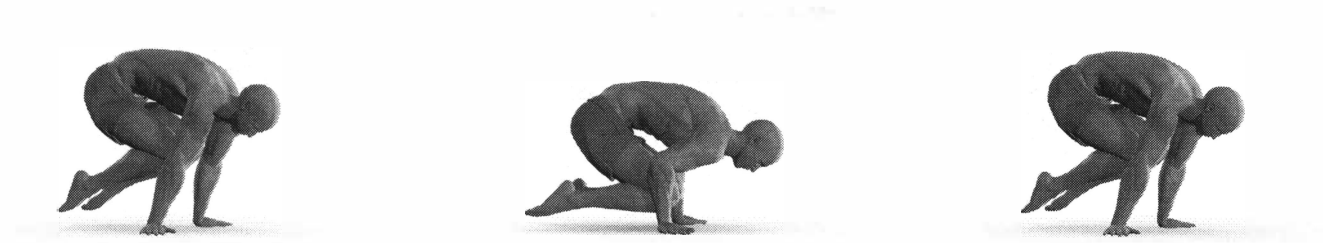
The planche pushup progression is an excellent supplement to build your strength for planche isometrics, as you will need to be able to control your body as you move in and out of the planche position and be able to pause in an isometric hold at the top of the movement. Even without the isometrics, this progression is excellent in its own right for building overall strength. Generally speaking, these pushup variations will typically lag one progression behind their isometric variations.

Three common faults with planche pushups (all variations) are delineated below:

1. It is common to not be aware of your body when beginning this movement, and it is easy to forget where you are in space. Dropping or elevating your hips will bring your center of mass closer to your arms. This will decrease the leverage against your shoulders and make the movement much easier to perform. Your body may tend to do this naturally, to compensate for weakness. It should be avoided. A spotter can tell you that you are too high or low, or you can use a camera to track your body positions from set to set so any faults can be corrected.
2. The hardest part of the movement is locking your elbows at the top and then pausing in a planche isometric position. It was mentioned earlier that bending your arms, even slightly, makes the isometric significantly easier. By extension, locking your arms straight is the most difficult position. It is common to see videos where people do not lock their arms while performing planche pushups. This flaw is fatal to your overall strength training. Not only are you reinforcing a fault while practicing the planche isometric, you are also missing out on hard-earned transitional strength that is acquired from moving from bent-arm to straight-arm strength.
3. The last fault has to do with your shoulders. When new trainees start to support themselves on their hands it is easy for them to be lazy with their scapulas. For instance, when you see a trainee attempting a planche they usually engage their shoulders as they lean forward, but they allow their scapulas to relax and stick out from the back. You should not allow this to occur. Focus on pushing your hands as far away from your body as possible at all times. This keeps your scapulas pinned against your rib cage. This increases their congruency with your rib cage and thus provides a more overall stable shoulder girdle. This will help increase force output from your shoulder and help stabilize the skill. If you are having issues with being able to keep your scapulas against your ribs, add some scapular pushups to your routine to work on your serratus anterior, which is the muscle responsible for this action.

Keep all of these common faults in mind when training these progressions.

TUCK PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and fully depressed without rounding your upper back. They will retract through the eccentric portion of the movement and be fully retracted at the bottom. As you rise back up to the starting position, your scapulas will protract. They will end protracted and fully depressed.

Technique: At this point, you should be able to perform a solid tuck planche. This skill begins in a tuck planche isometric hold, with the back rounded and hips at shoulder height. From here, lower your body in a slow and controlled manner. This may appear to be a dip position, with your elbows fully bent and hands near your shoulders, however, the significant difference is a forward lean—enough to keep your hips at shoulder height. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, you can pause (if desired), then begin the concentric movement back to a straight-arm tuck position. Emphasize the starting position by holding it for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

You can perform this movement on the ground, but if you desire to increase your range of motion you can perform this movement on parallettes, chairs, or other implements that will increase the height of your body. This will make the movement much more difficult, but it will also increase strength and hypertrophy. Parallettes are recommended, if they are available to you.

Keeping your hips level with your shoulders during the entire movement is the hardest element of this skill. You must push forward and downward with your hands for the duration of the skill to maintain this position. Even if you have the strength to do this, you may be inconsistent. Practice with strict form; it will help you in subsequent progressions.

ADVANCED TUCK PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 8

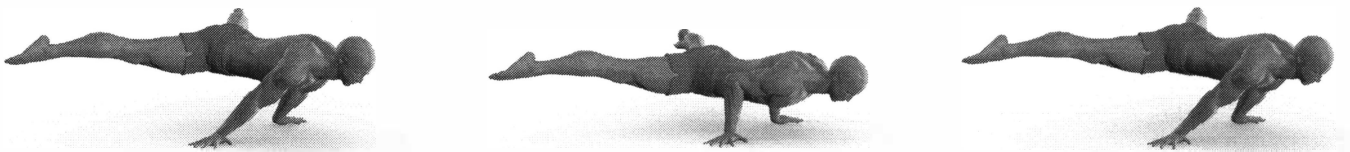


Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and fully depressed without rounding your upper back. They will retract through the eccentric portion of the movement and be fully retracted at the bottom. As you rise back up to the starting position, your scapulas will protract. They will end protracted and fully depressed.

Technique: For the advanced tuck planche position you want a flat back, your shoulders/hips aligned and parallel to the ground, and your hips/knees bent at ninety-degree angles. From here, lower your body in a slow and controlled manner. This may appear to be a dip position, with your elbows fully bent and hands near your shoulders, however, the significant difference is a forward lean—enough to keep your hips at shoulder height. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, you can pause (if desired), then begin the concentric movement back to a straight-arm tuck position. Emphasize the starting position by holding it for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

You will likely not reach this level until you can execute a decent straddle planche. Be conservative with these progressions and try not to advance too rapidly. Executing these with perfect form is better than wobbling and constantly changing shoulder and hip angles due to advancing levels prematurely.

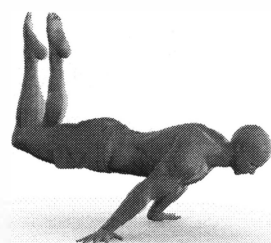
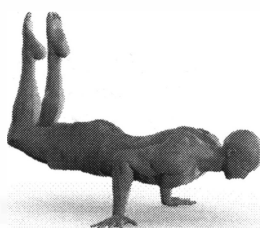
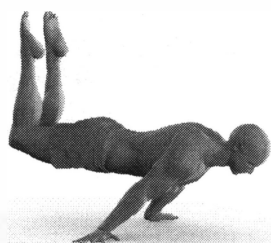
STRADDLE PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and fully depressed without rounding your upper back. They will retract through the eccentric portion of the movement and be fully retracted at the bottom. As you rise back up to the starting position, your scapulas will protract. They will end protracted and fully depressed.

Technique: The straddle planche is executed with a straight-body position and your legs apart. You should maintain a straight line from your shoulders through your hips/knees/ankles to your toes, but you should also have your legs spread as far apart as possible. From here, lower your body in a slow and controlled manner. It will look and feel like a dip position, with your elbows fully bent and hands near your shoulders, however, there is a forward lean—enough to keep your hips at shoulder height. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, you can pause (if desired), then begin the concentric movement back to a straight-arm tuck position. Emphasize the starting position by holding it for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

The most difficult part of the *straddle planche pushup* is maintaining your hip height, especially at the bottom and top of the movement where it is most difficult. Focus on keeping a tight body to increase tension so you do not cheat the movement. You will be tempted to hollow or arch your body out of straight-body alignment. Resist this temptation.

HALF LAYOUT / ONE-LEG-OUT PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 12

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and fully depressed without rounding your upper back. They will retract through the eccentric portion of the movement and be fully retracted at the bottom. As you rise back up to the starting position, your scapulas will protract. They will end protracted and fully depressed.

Technique: In the half layout position, your knees and legs are together and all of your joints are aligned—from your shoulders through your hips and knees through your legs—except your knees are bent at a ninety-degree angle. The one-leg-out position is the same as the straight-body position except one leg is bent at both the hips and knee, similar to an advanced tuck position. Choose if you are doing one-leg-out or half-layout and then lower your body in a slow and controlled manner. Similar to a dip position, your elbows are fully bent and hands are near your shoulders, however there is also a forward lean—enough to keep your hips at shoulder height. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, you can pause (if desired), then begin the concentric movement back to a straight-arm tuck position. Emphasize the starting position by holding it for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

If you are on the ground, the one-leg-out position can interfere with performing the planche pushup variation. Use the half layout position to perform this intermediate step between straddle and full planche pushups.

FULL PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 14



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be protracted and fully depressed without rounding your upper back. They will retract through the eccentric portion of the movement and be fully retracted at the bottom. As you rise back up to the starting position, your scapulas will protract. They will end protracted and fully depressed.

Technique: For the full planche, align your body straight and parallel with the ground from your shoulders through your torso/hips/knees/ankles to your toes. From here, lower your body into a descent in a slow and controlled manner. This is similar to a dip position, with your elbows fully bent and hands near your shoulders, however, you must add a forward lean—enough to keep your hips at shoulder height. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, you can pause (if desired), then begin the concentric movement back to a straight-arm tuck position. Emphasize the starting position by holding it for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

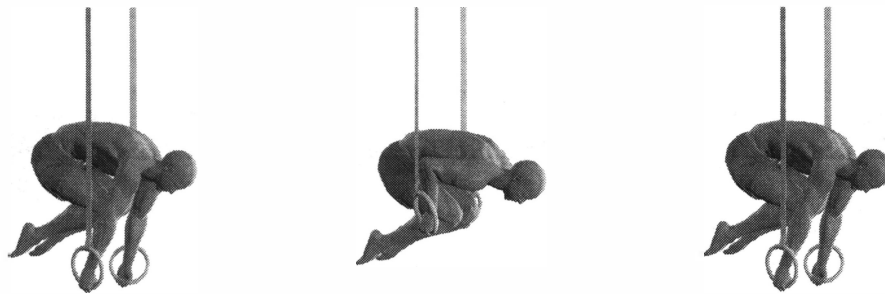
Full planche pushups are incredibly advanced. Like full front lever rows, it will be difficult to truly obtain a full range of motion. With the full variations of these skills, you may only be able to move six to eight inches while performing the movement. However, if you continue working them, you should aim for a greater range of motion in order to build more strength.

Rings Planche Pushups – Page 3, Column 4

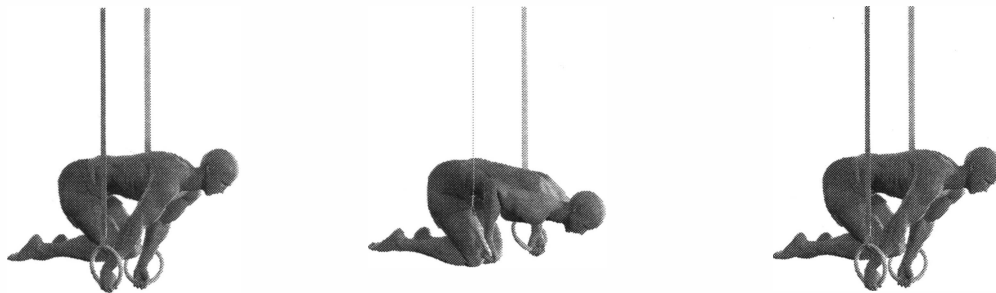
Rings planche pushups are extremely difficult, but are tremendously rewarding if you can build enough strength to begin training this progression. If you reach the advance tuck or straddle levels, you will have advanced beyond the usefulness of this book. All of these skills are the same as the previous progression but performed on the rings. Remember the following:

- Keep the rings turned out to at least parallel to ninety degrees for the duration of the skill.
- Keep your hips (and any other body part) level with your shoulders for the duration of the skill.
- Keep your elbow fully locked out in the top of the isometric position between repetitions.
- Keep the rings as steady as possible.

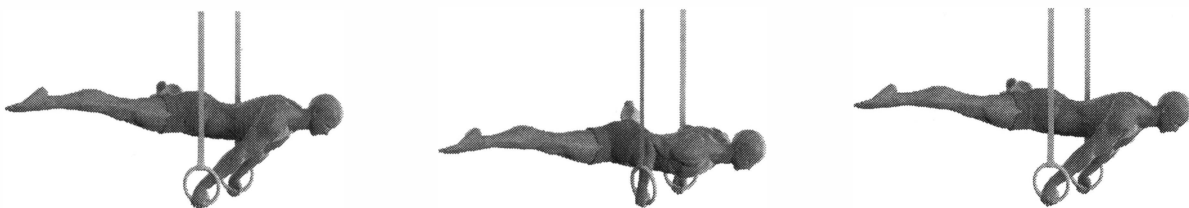
RINGS TUCK PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 8



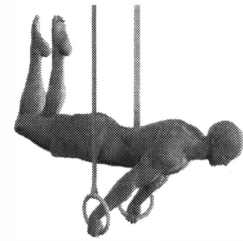
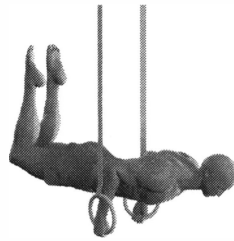
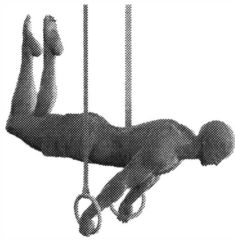
RINGS ADVANCED TUCK PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 10



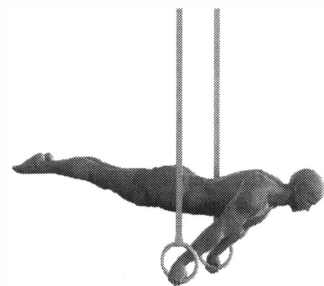
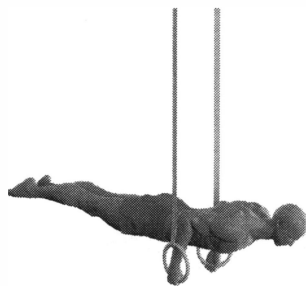
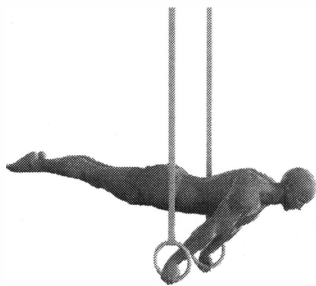
RINGS STRADDLE PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 12



RINGS HALF LAYOUT / ONE-LEG-OUT PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 14

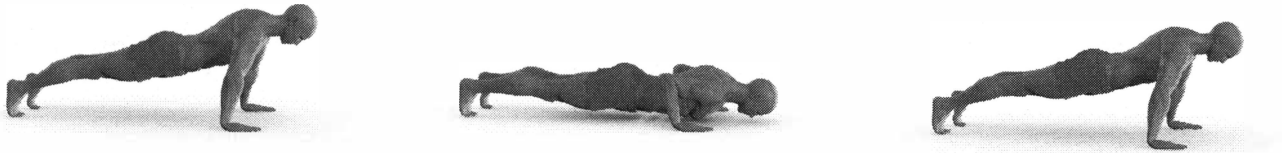


RINGS FULL PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 16



Pushups – Page 3, Column 5

STANDARD PUSHUPS – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: Many articles have been written on correct technique for *standard pushups*. Here are the basics. You should be able to progress to more difficult skill rather quickly.

Here are a couple of key points for performing quality pushups:

- Hold your body perfectly straight or in a slightly hollow position by squeezing your glutes and tensing your abdominals. All parts of your body should touch the ground at the same time.
- Your elbows should not flare out during the movement. Flaring your elbows out to a ninety-degree angle with the rest of your body is incorrect pushup technique, and this may lead to shoulder injuries. Flared elbows can be used in a few of the more advanced progressions, but not in any of the high-level progressions since this technique can be dangerous in the long run. Instead, tuck your elbows in toward your body from anywhere between a zero to forty-five degree angle.
- Do not shortcut your range of motion. This is true for all movements. It is not a race. Perform a controlled eccentric phase to the chest brushing the ground and a powerful concentric phase finishing with your elbows locking out at the top.

Pushups can sometimes cause back pain. If you arch your back during the movement, it activates your psoas muscles (which help keep your hips neutral) more than your abdominals. The psoas major muscle has its origin on your lumbar spine. Therefore, if your body is allowed to arch and the psoas muscle pulls on your lower back, pain can occur while performing any variation of pushups.

If the exercise is too difficult at first you can scale it by straddling or moving to your knees. You can also incline your body by placing your hands on stairs or an elevated surface.

Once you can perform sets of fifteen to twenty repetitions, move on to more difficult pushup progressions.

DIAMOND PUSHUPS – LEVEL 2

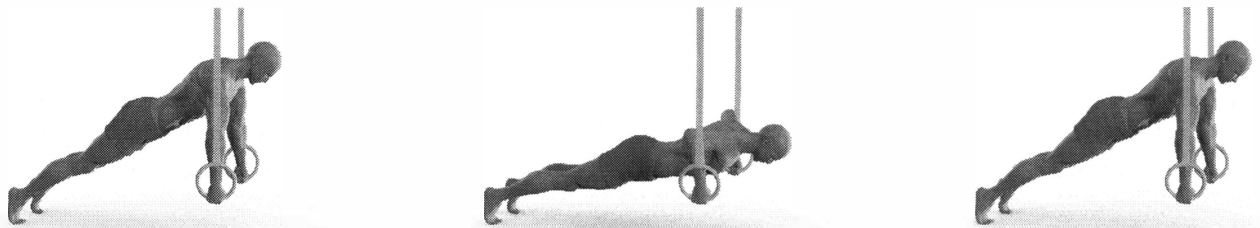


Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: *Diamond pushups* take standard pushups a step further. They bring your hands closer together to make the pushup harder. Eventually your index fingers and thumbs will meet in the middle to form a diamond shape. During the movement, lower your chest to the middle of your hands and then return to the original position. A triceps-biased alternative is to touch your nose inside the diamond created by your index finger and thumbs.

This technique puts a lot of stress on your triceps and chest due to increased torque at your elbows and shoulders. Be cautious if your joints start to ache, especially between exercise sessions. This may be a signal of overuse. If this is the case, take a break from these exercises for a couple of days (if not more) to allow your body to fully recover before resuming. You do not want to have any nagging injuries as the progressions get more difficult.

RINGS WIDE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 3



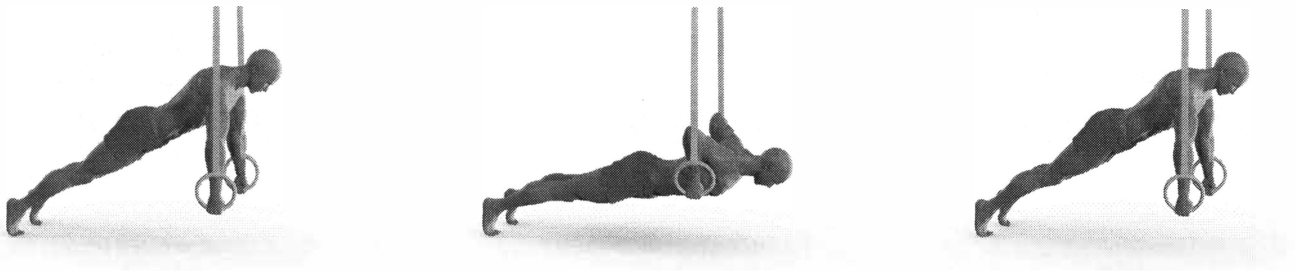
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: *Rings wide pushups* are performed by keeping your elbows in line with each other and your clavicles, allowing them to come out as the distance between your hands is increased while moving into the bottom of the position. From there, push out and bring your hands together.

These pushups place emphasis on the chest, which is critical to prepare for future training. If you jump too far ahead in progressions, you may experience twinges of pain in the origins of your pectoralis muscle groups resulting in injuries like costochondritis or tietze syndrome. Even if you are strong enough to perform these techniques, it may be wise to add them to your warm-up to ensure that your connective tissues are up to par. If you feel any type of pain or instability at your joints, skip this progression completely.

Note that the pushups progression started with elbows tucked in, but this progression utilizes elbows wide at the ninety degree angle. Widening the angle is often used as a progression method, but it is best to start with elbows tucked as it is safer for the shoulders. Skip this progression if you find that elbows wider bothers you.

RINGS PUSHUPS – LEVEL 4



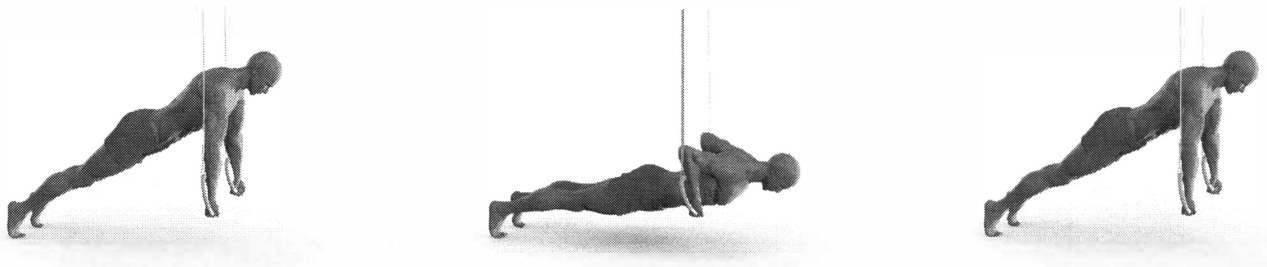
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: *Rings pushups* are like standard pushups, but performed on the rings. They are performed with your hands at the same level as your feet, so the rings must be lowered so that they are close to the ground. Alternatively, you can raise your feet on a box or block. For rings pushups, you want to emphasize keeping your elbows in—at a thirty-degree angle from your body (though anywhere from zero to forty-five degrees is acceptable). This puts most of the focus for developing strength on your shoulders and triceps. From there, the movement is just like a standard pushup.

For all of these pushup progressions, ensure that you are moving through full range of motion. It is very common to see individuals shortcut pushups by not going all the way down and not coming all the way back up. While this may yield more repetitions, it does not fully strengthen your muscles, which is your goal. Since bodyweight strength training puts your muscles in many different positions, it is important to perform everything through full range of motion. This is even more important when training on the rings.

For all pushups, your hands must meet your torso at the bottom of the position, your arms must be straight at the top, and proper body positioning should be maintained throughout.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT PUSHUPS – LEVEL 5



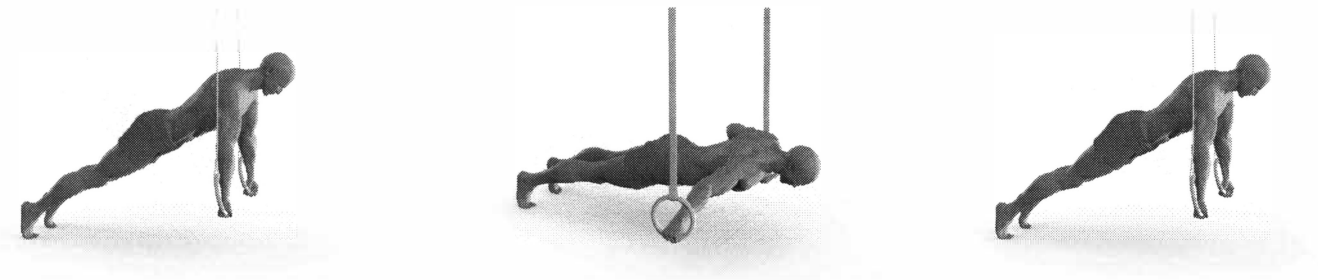
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: These pushups should be performed with your palms facing forward—at least forty-five degrees from the parallel position—with the optimal palm position being fully forward at ninety degrees from parallel. When you first attempt to turn the rings out, you may have difficulty stabilizing yourself. Persevere until you get the hang of it. From this point on, the movement is simply a standard pushup. When your hands are level with your torso, you are at the accepted bottom position. Push back up and make sure your arms are straight at the top position.

Rings-turned-out pushups (which can be abbreviated *RTO PU*) decrease leverage at your shoulders by lengthening your pectoralis muscles. Since your pecs are a stabilizer during the movement, a decrease in stabilization will require an increase in strength to perform the movement. In this position, your biceps are recruited to help, however, they are also elongated, making them relatively weaker. This is true for all RTO movements. Turning rings out will eventually give you more control over the movements.

Even after you have stabilized the support position for the pushup, there will be destabilization when you go down into the pushup position for the first time. Keep the rings turned out and stabilize them as best as possible. It will get easier with practice, and you will get stronger because of it.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT ARCHER PUSHUPS – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: Archer pushups are similar to standard pushups, but one arm is kept straight for the duration of the movement. Select an arm to keep straight and turn the rings out in the pushup support position. Descend into the movement. When you reach the bottom position, your straight arm should be out wide. Next, push back up with your bent arm. You can assist your other arm, but it must be kept straight the entire time. Once you have accomplished this, switch to the other arm for a full workout.

When performing *rings-turned-out archer pushups* (which can be abbreviated *RTO Archer PU*), it is acceptable if you cannot immediately hold your arm fully straight. Work on progressively straightening your arm for the full archer pushup effect. This will help you increase the bias of strength onto each of your arms.

You can bias the movement more toward your straight or bent arm to varying effect by putting more weight on the arm that is straight or bent, respectively. Biasing toward the straight arm tends to work your chest and shoulder more, and biasing toward the bent arm tends to work your triceps and shoulders more. Focus on improving your weaknesses over favoring your current strengths.